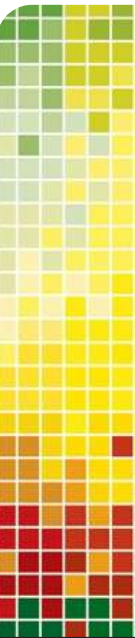


Chapter | 6 | Correspondence



>>> Chapter Objectives

In this chapter, students will

- Learn general guidelines for all correspondence
- Learn the general ABC format for all correspondence
- Learn strategies for writing positive, negative, neutral, and persuasive messages
- Learn special considerations for writing letters: correspondence to readers outside an organization
- Learn special considerations for writing memos: correspondence within an organization
- Learn special considerations for writing e-mail: correspondence that can be sent both outside of and within an organization
- Learn the ABC format for e-mail
- Learn guidelines for choosing whether to send a memo or an e-mail message
- Read and analyze model correspondence

Marie Stargill, M-Global's fire science expert, just returned from a seminar that emphasized new techniques for preventing injuries from job site fires. Within 24 hours of her return, she has already done three things:

1. Written her manager an e-mail message over the office computer network
2. Sent a letter to an M-Global client suggesting use of fire-retardant gloves she learned about at the seminar
3. Sent the conference director a letter of appreciation about the meeting

Like Marie, you will write many letters, memos, and e-mails in your career. In fact, you probably will write more of this correspondence than any other type of document.

Letters, memos, and e-mails are short documents written to accomplish a limited purpose. Letters are directed outside your organization, memos are directed within your organization, and e-mail can be directed to either an external or an internal audience. (Longer, more complicated letters and memos—called *letter reports* and *memo reports*—are covered in Chapter 10.) Here are some working definitions:

Letter: A document that conveys information to a member of one organization from someone outside that same

organization. Letters usually cover one major point and fit on one page.

Memo: A document written from a member of an organization to one or more members of the same organization. Memos usually cover just one main point and no more than a few. Readers prefer one-page memos.

E-mail: A document often written in an informal style either to members of one's own organization or to an external audience. E-mail messages usually cover one main point. Characterized by the speed with which it is written and delivered, an e-mail can include more formal attachments to be read and possibly printed by the recipient.

Your ability to write good memos, letters, and e-mails, like other forms of technical communication, depends on a clear sense of purpose, thorough understanding of reader needs, and close attention to correct formats. This chapter prepares you for this challenge by presenting sections that cover

1. General rules that apply to all workplace correspondence
2. Specific formats for positive messages, negative messages, neutral messages, and persuasive messages
3. Guidelines for letters, memos, and e-mail

Job letters and résumés are discussed in a separate chapter on the job search (Chapter 16).

>>> General Guidelines for Correspondence

Letters convey your message to readers outside your organization, just as memos are an effective way to get things done within your own organization, and e-mail is a way to communicate quickly with readers inside and outside your organization. By applying the guidelines in this chapter, you can master the craft of writing effective correspondence. You must plan, draft, and revise each letter, memo, and e-mail as if your job depends on it—for it may.

Refer to Models 6–1, 6–2, and 6–3 on pages 182–185 for M-Global examples that demonstrate the guidelines that follow. Later examples in this chapter illustrate specific guidelines for letters, memos, and e-mail.

>> Correspondence Guideline 1: Know Your Purpose

Before beginning your draft, write down your purpose in one clear sentence. This approach forces you to sift through details to find a main reason for writing every letter or memo. This *purpose sentence* often becomes one of the first sentences in the document. Following are some samples:

- **Letter purpose sentence:** “As you requested yesterday, I am sending samples of the new candy brands you are considering placing in M-Global’s office vending machines.”
- **Memo purpose sentence:** “This memo explains M-Global’s new policy for selecting rental cars on business trips.”
- **E-mail purpose sentence:** “I have attached the most recent draft of the proposal for the PI Corp. pipeline project.”

Some purpose statements are implied; others are stated. An implied purpose statement occurs in the second paragraph of Models 6–1. This paragraph shows that the writer wishes both to respond to requests for M-Global brochures and, just as important, to seek the professor’s help in soliciting good graduates for M-Global’s Atlanta office. In a sense, one purpose leads into the other. Models 6–2 shows a more obvious purpose statement in the second sentence, directly stating the contents of the memo.

>> Correspondence Guideline 2: Know Your Readers

Who are you trying to inform or influence? The answer to this question affects the vocabulary you choose, the arguments you make, and the tone you adopt. Pay particular attention when correspondence will be read by more than one person. If these readers are from different technical levels or different administrative levels within an organization, the challenge increases. A complex audience compels you to either reduce the level of technicality to one that can be understood by all readers or write different parts of the document for different readers.

Models 6–1 is directed to a professor with whom the writer wants to develop a reciprocal relationship—that is, George Lux gives free guest lectures in civil engineering classes, hoping the professor will in turn help him inform potential job applicants about M-Global. Models 6–2, directed to an in-house technical audience, contains fairly general information about the new technical editor. This information applies to, and should be understood by, all readers. Models 6–3 is typical of e-mail between people who know each other professionally. It has a conversational tone not found in other forms of correspondence.



George Doyle/Thinkstock

>> Correspondence Guideline 3: Follow Correct Format

Most organizations adopt letter and memo formats that must be used uniformly by all employees. You should learn the formats that your organization uses, but most correspondence follows these basic guidelines:

■ **Letters:** There are three main letter formats—block, modified block, and simplified. Figures 6–1, 6–2, and 6–3 show the basic page design of each; letter examples throughout the chapter use the three formats. Some letters, like the one in Model 6–6 on page 188, include a subject line or attention line instead of the salutation line. As noted, you usually follow the preferred format of your own organization.

Addresses on envelopes and in letters should use the format recommended by the U.S. Postal Service. Addresses should include no more than four lines, and should not include punctuation such as commas or periods.

■ **Memos:** With minor variations, all memos look much the same. The obligatory “Date/To/From/Subject” information hangs at the top left margin, in whatever order your organization requires. Figure 6–4 shows one basic format. These four lines allow you to dispense with lengthy introductory passages seen in more formal documents. Note that the sender signs his or her initials after or above the typed name in the “From” line.

■ **Letters and memos:** Some format conventions apply to both letters and memos. Three of the more important features are:

Reference initials: If the document has been typed by someone other than the writer, place the typist’s initials two lines beneath the signature block for letters and below the last paragraph for memos (e.g., jt). Some organizations prefer that the initials of the writer also be included, followed by those of the typist (e.g., GTY/jt).

Enclosure notation: If attachments or enclosures accompany the letter or memo, type the singular or plural form of “Enclosure” or “Attachment” one or two lines beneath the reference initials. Some writers also list the item itself (e.g., Enclosure: Specification Sheet B54321).

Multiple-page headings: Each page after the first page often has a heading that includes the name of the person or company receiving the letter or memo, the date, and the page number. Some organizations may prefer an abbreviated form such as “Jones to Bingham, 2,” without the date.

■ **E-mail:** Computers and e-mail systems handle formatting of texts and special characters differently, so you should format your e-mail so that it can be read on any computer. Use your system’s default font, and avoid highlighting, color, bold, italics, and underlining. E-mails are generally short, a length that can be seen on a computer screen all at once, and paragraphs should be short. Some e-mail systems can’t translate tab indentations at the beginning of paragraphs, so use lines of white space between paragraphs.

Letterhead of your organization

Two or more blank lines (adjust space to center letter on page)

Date of letter

Two or more blank lines (adjust space to center letter on page)

Address of reader

One blank line

Greeting

One blank line

Paragraph: single-spaced (indenting optional)

One blank line

Paragraph: single-spaced (indenting optional)

One blank line

Paragraph: single-spaced (indenting optional)

One blank line

Complimentary close

Three blank lines (for signature)

Typed name and title

One blank line

Typist's initials (optional: Writer's initials before typist's initials)

Computer file # (if applicable)

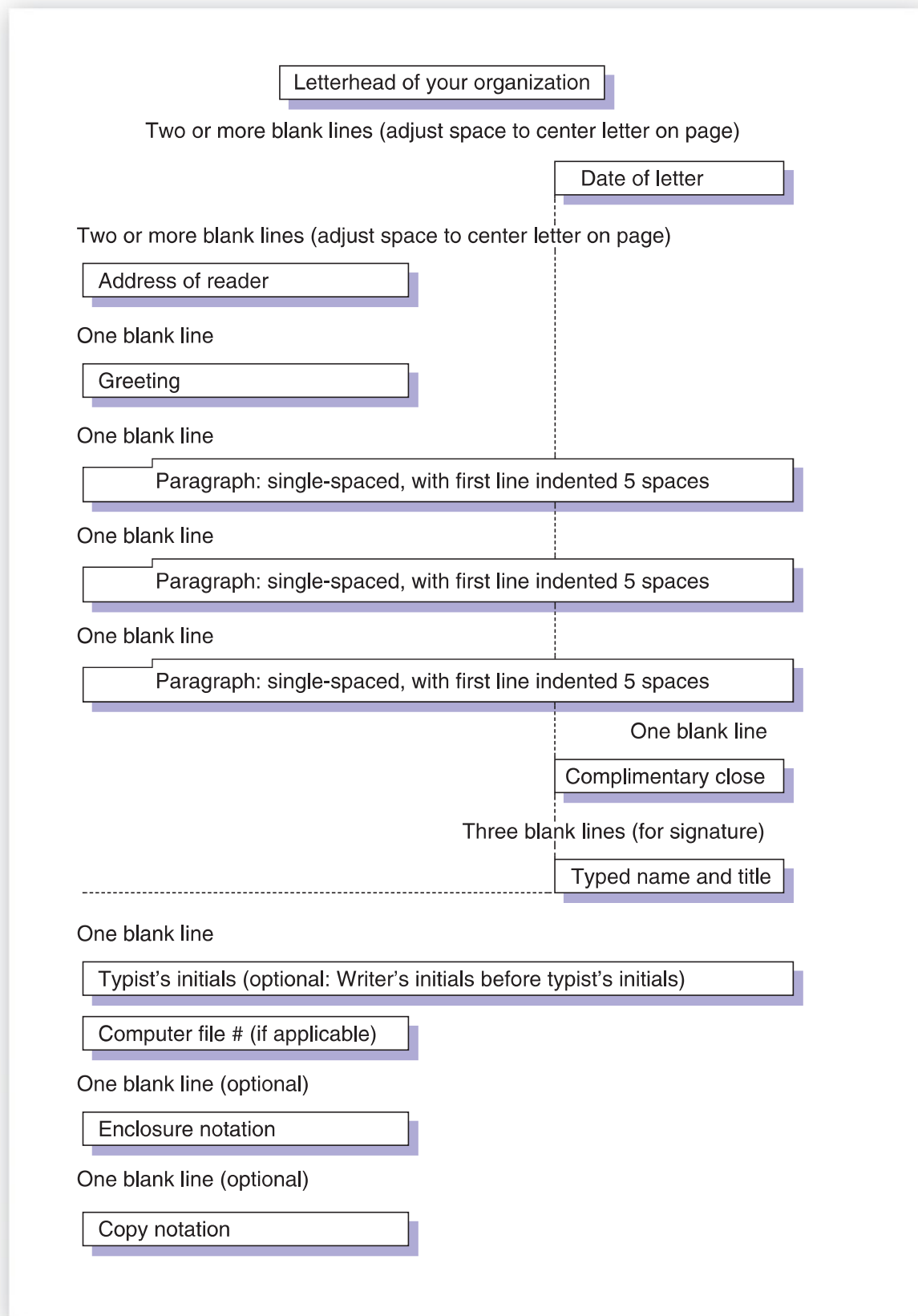
One blank line (optional)

Enclosure notation

One blank line (optional)

Copy notation

■ Figure 6-1 ■ Block style for letters



■ **Figure 6-2** ■ Modified block style (with indented paragraphs) for letters

Letterhead of organization

Two or more blank lines (adjust space to center letter on page)

Date of letter

Two or more blank lines (adjust space to center letter on page)

Address of reader

Three blank lines

Short subject line

Three blank lines

Paragraph: single-spaced, no indenting

One blank line

Paragraph: single-spaced, no indenting

One blank line

Paragraph: single-spaced, no indenting

Five blank lines (for signature)

Typed name and title

One blank line (optional)

Typist's initials (optional: Writer's initials before typist's initials)

Computer file # (if applicable)

One blank line (optional)

Enclosure notation

One blank line (optional)

Copy notation

■ **Figure 6-3** ■ Simplified style for letters

In memos and e-mails, give the subject line special attention because it telegraphs meaning to the audience immediately. In fact, readers use it to decide when, or if, they will read the complete correspondence. Be brief, but also engage interest. For example, the subject line of the Model 6-2 memo could have been “Editing.” Yet that brevity would have sacrificed reader interest. The actual subject line, “New employee to help

■ Figure 6-4 ■

Memo style

Facsimile reference
One or more blank lines
Date of memo
Reader's name (and position, if appropriate)
Writer's name (and position, if appropriate)
Subject of memo
One or more blank lines
Paragraph: Single-spaced (optional—first line indented)
One blank line
Paragraph: Single-spaced (optional—first line indented)
One blank line
Paragraph: Single-spaced (optional—first line indented)
One blank line
Typist's initials (optional—writer's initials before typist's initials)
One blank line
Enclosure notation
One blank line
Copy notation

with technical editing,” conveys more information and shows readers that the contents of the memo will make their lives easier.

■ **Letters, memos, and e-mail:** Some format conventions apply to all three forms of correspondence. Two of the more important features are:

Copy notation: If the correspondence has been sent to anyone other than the recipient, type “Copy” or “Copies” one or two lines beneath the enclosure notation, followed by the name(s) of the person or persons receiving copies (e.g., Copy: Preston Hinkley). Some organizations prefer the initials “c” (for *copy*), “cc” (for *carbon copy*, even though carbons rarely exist anymore), or “pc” (for *photo-copy*). E-mail inserts this information automatically. If you are sending a copy but do not want the original letter or memo to include a reference to that copy, write “bc” (for *blind copy*) and the person’s name only on the copy—not on the original (e.g., bc: Jim McDuff). (Note: Send blind copies only when you are certain it is appropriate and ethical to do so. See page 170–171 in this chapter for more on sending copies.)

Postscripts: Items marked “PS” or “P.S.” appear occasionally in letters and rarely in memos. They are considered by many readers to be symbols of poor planning, so use them with caution. If used, they appear as the last item on the document (beneath the copy notation) and can be typed or written in longhand.

>> **Correspondence Guideline 4: Follow the ABC Format for All Correspondence**

Correspondence subscribes to the same three-part ABC (*Abstract/Body/Conclusion*) format used throughout this book. This approach responds to each reader’s need to know “What does this document have to do with me?” According to the ABC format, your correspondence is composed of these three main sections:

■ **Abstract:** The abstract introduces the purpose and usually gives a summary of main points to follow. It includes one or two short paragraphs.

■ **Body:** The body contains supporting details and thus makes up the largest part of a letter or memo. You can help your readers by using such techniques as:

Deductive patterns for paragraphs: In this general-to-specific plan, your first sentence should state the point that helps the reader understand the rest of the paragraph. This pattern avoids burying important points in the middle or end of the paragraph, where they might be missed. Fast readers tend to focus on paragraph beginnings and expect to find crucial information there. Note how most paragraphs in Model 6–2 follow this format.

Lists that break up the text: Listed points are a good strategy for highlighting details. Readers are especially attracted to groupings of three items, which create a certain rhythm, attract attention, and encourage recall. Use bullets, numbers, dashes, or other typographic techniques to signal the listed items. For example, the bulleted list in Model 6–1 draws attention to three important points about M-Global that the writer wants to emphasize. Because some e-mail systems can’t read special characters like bullets, use asterisks or dashes for lists in e-mail.

Headings to divide information: One-page letters and memos, and even e-mail, sometimes benefit from the emphasis achieved by headings. The three headings in Model 6–2 quickly steer the reader to main parts of the document.

■ **Conclusion:** Readers remember first what they read last. The final paragraph of your correspondence should leave the reader with an important piece of information—for example, a summary of the main idea or a clear statement of what will happen next. The Model 6–1 letter makes an offer that helps continue the reader’s association with the university, whereas the Model 6–2 memo gives readers specific issues to study before the next meeting.

Your final paragraph in external correspondence should always continue the business relationship by encouraging future contact. Internal correspondence may also include a statement offering to answer questions or concerns. The final paragraph in the Model 6–1 letter encourages the reader to call, and the final paragraph in the original e-mail in Model 6–3 specifically encourages the recipient to respond with questions or concerns.

>> Correspondence Guideline 5: Use the 3Cs Strategy

The ABC format provides a way to organize all letters and memos. Another pattern of organization for you to use is the *3Cs strategy*—especially when your correspondence has a persuasive objective. This strategy has three main goals:

- **Capture** the reader’s attention with a good opener, which tells the reader what the letter, memo, or e-mail can do for him or her.
- **Convince** the reader with supporting points, all of which confirm the opening point that this document will help the reader meet his or her goals.
- **Contact** solidifies your relationship with the reader with an offer to follow up on the correspondence.

Although neither Model 6–1 nor Model 6–2 is overtly persuasive, each has an underlying persuasive purpose, as does the original message in Model 6–3. Note how each uses the 3Cs strategy.

>> Correspondence Guideline 6: Stress the “You” Attitude

Begin writing correspondence by looking at the subject from your reader’s perspective. Ask yourself, “What will interest my reader?” and “What does my reader want to accomplish?” For example, you should perform the following tasks:

- Anticipate questions your reader might raise and then answer these questions. You can even follow an actual question (“And how will our new testing lab help your firm?”) with an answer (“Now M-Global’s labs can process samples in 24 hours”).
- Replace the pronouns *I*, *me*, and *we* with *you* and *your*. Of course, you must use first-person pronouns at certain points in a letter, but many pronouns should be second person. The technique is quite simple. You can change almost any sentence from writer-focused prose (“We feel that this new service will . . .”) to reader-focused prose (“You’ll find that this new service will . . .”).

Model 6–1 shows this *you* attitude by emphasizing what M-Global and the writer himself can do for the professor and his students. Model 6–2 shows it by emphasizing that the new editor will make the readers’ jobs easier.

>> Correspondence Guideline 7: Use Attachments for Details

Keep text brief by placing details in attachments, which readers can examine later, rather than bogging down the middle of the letter or memo. This way, the supporting facts are available for future reference, without distracting readers from the main message. The memo in Model 6–2, for example, includes an attached list of possible job tasks for the new M-Global editor. The listing would only clutter the body of the memo, especially because its purpose is to stimulate discussion at the next meeting.

>> Correspondence Guideline 8: Be Diplomatic

Without a tactful tone, all of your planning and drafting will be wasted. Choose words that persuade, not demand. Be especially careful with memos written to subordinates. If

you sound too authoritarian, your message may be ignored—even if it is clear that what you are suggesting will help the readers. Generally speaking, negative (or “bad news”) letters often use the passive voice, whereas positive (or “good news”) letters often use the active voice.

For example, the letter in Model 6–1 would fail in its purpose if it sounded too pushy and one-sided about M-Global’s interest in hiring graduates. Similarly, the editing memo in Model 6–2 would be poorly received if it used stuffy and condescending wording, such as “Be advised that starting next month, you are to make use of proofreading services provided in-house by. . . .”

>> Correspondence Guideline 9: Edit Carefully

Because letters, memos, and e-mail are short, editing errors may be obvious to readers. Take special care to avoid the following errors:

■ Mechanics

- Misspelled words of any kind, but especially the reader’s name
- Wrong job title (call the reader’s office to double-check, if necessary)
- Old address (again, call the reader’s office to check)

■ Grammar

- Subject-verb and pronoun agreement errors
- Misused commas

■ Style

- Stuffy phrases, such as “Per your request” and “Enclosed herewith”
- Long sentences with more than one main and one dependent clause
- Phrases that make presumptions, such as “Thanking you in advance for . . .”
- Negative tone suggested by phrases such as “We cannot,” “I won’t,” and “Please don’t hesitate to”

The last point is crucial and gets more attention later in this chapter. Use the editing stage to rewrite any passage that could be phrased in a more positive tone. You must always keep the reader’s goodwill, no matter what the message.

>> Correspondence Guideline 10: Respond Quickly

A letter, memo, or e-mail that comes too late fails in its purpose, no matter how well written. Mail letters within 48 hours of your contact with, or request from, the reader. Send memos in plenty of time for your reader to make the appropriate adjustments in schedule, behavior, and so forth. Respond to e-mails the same day you receive them. The first sentence in the Model 6–1 letter, for example, shows that George Lux writes the day after his guest lecture. This responsiveness helps secure the goodwill of the professor.



Correspondence Guidelines

- Know your purpose
- Know your readers
- Follow correct format
- Follow the ABC format for all correspondence
- Use the 3Cs strategy
- Stress the “you” attitude
- Use attachments for details
- Be diplomatic
- Edit carefully
- Respond quickly

>>> Types of Messages in Correspondence

This section gives you specific guidelines for the following documents:

- Correspondence with a positive message
- Correspondence with a negative message
- Correspondence with a neutral message
- Correspondence with a persuasive message

To be sure, many documents are hybrid forms that combine these patterns. As a technical sales expert for M-Global, for example, you may be writing to answer a customer question about a new piece of equipment just purchased from M-Global’s Equipment Development Lab. Your main task is to solve a problem

caused by a confusing passage in the owner’s manual. At the same time, however, your concern about the customer’s satisfaction can pave the way for purchase of a second machine later in the year. Thus the letter has both a positive message and a persuasive message. This example also points to a common thread that weaves all four message types together: the need to maintain the reader’s goodwill toward you and your organization.

The next four sections present a pattern for each type of correspondence, based on the ABC format used throughout this text; as well as one or more brief case studies in which the pattern might be used at M-Global.

Positive Messages

Everyone likes to give good news; fortunately, you will often be in the position of providing it when you write. Following are some sample situations:

- Letter replying to a question about products or services
- Letter responding favorably to a complaint or an adjustment
- Letter hiring an employee
- Memo announcing high bonuses for the fiscal year
- Memo informing employees about improved fringe benefits
- E-mail commending an employee for performance on a project

The trick is to recognize the good-news potential of many situations. This section gives you an all-purpose format for positive correspondence, followed by a case study from M-Global.

ABC Format for Positive Correspondence

All positive messages follow one overriding rule. You must always:

State good news immediately!

Any delay gives readers the chance to wonder whether the news will be good or bad, thus causing momentary confusion. On the left is a complete outline for positive correspondence that corresponds to the ABC format.

M-Global Case Study for a Positive Letter

As a project manager at M-Global's Houston office, Nancy Slade has agreed to complete a foundation investigation for a large church about 300 miles away. There are cracks in the basement floor slab and doors that do not close, so her crew needs a day to analyze the problem (observing the site, measuring walls, digging soil borings, taking samples, etc.). She took this small job on the condition that she could schedule it around several larger (and more profitable) projects in the same area during mid-August.

Yesterday, Nancy received a letter from the minister (speaking for the church committee), who requested that M-Global change the date. He had just been asked by the regional headquarters to host a three-day conference at the church during the same time that M-Global was originally scheduled to complete the project.

After checking her project schedule, Nancy determines that she can reschedule the church job. Model 6–4 on page 186 shows her response to the minister.

ABC Format:

Positive Correspondence

- **ABSTRACT:** Puts correspondence in the context of an ongoing professional relationship by referring to previous communication related to the subject
 - Clear statement of good news you have to report
- **BODY:** Supporting data for main point mentioned in abstract
 - Clarification of any questions reader may have
 - Qualification, if any, of the good news
- **CONCLUSION:** Statement of eagerness to continue relationship, complete project, etc.
 - Clear statement, if appropriate, of what step should come next

Negative Messages

It would be nice if all your correspondence could be as positive as the one just described. Unfortunately, the real world does not work that way. You will have many opportunities to display both tact and clarity in relating negative information. Following are a few cases:

- Letter explaining delays in projects or delivery of services
- Letter refusing to make adjustments based on complaints
- Letter giving bad news about employment or performance
- Memo reporting decreased quarterly revenues for the year
- Memo requesting closer attention to filling out time sheets
- E-mail asking for volunteers to work on a holiday

This section gives you a format to follow in writing sensitive correspondence with negative information. Then it provides one application at M-Global.

ABC Format for Negative Correspondence

One main rule applies to all negative correspondence:

Buffer the bad news, but still be clear.

ABC Format: Negative Correspondence

- **ABSTRACT:** Puts correspondence in the context of an ongoing professional relationship by referring to previous communication related to the subject
 - General statement of purpose or appreciation—in an effort to find common bond or area of agreement
- **BODY:** Strong emphasis on what can be done, when possible
 - Buffered yet clear statement of what cannot be done, with clear statement of reasons for negative news
 - Facts that support your views
- **CONCLUSION:** Closing remarks that express interest in continued association
 - Statement, if appropriate, of what will happen next

Despite the bad news, you want to keep the reader's goodwill. Spend time at the beginning building your relationship with the reader by introducing less controversial information—before you zero in on the main message. On the right is an overall pattern to apply in all negative correspondence.

M-Global Case Study for a Negative Letter

Reread the letter situation described in the section on positive correspondence. Now, assume that instead of being able to comply with the minister's request, Nancy is unable to complete the work on another date without changing the fee. This change is necessary because Nancy must send a new crew 300 miles to the site, rather than using a crew already working on a nearby project.

Nancy knows the church is on a tight budget, but she also knows that M-Global would not be in business very long by working for free. Most important, because the church is asking for a change in the original agreement, she believes it is fair to request a change in the fee. Model 6–5 on page 187 is the letter she sends. Note her effort to buffer the negative news.

Neutral Messages

Some correspondence expresses neither positive nor negative news. It is simply the routine correspondence written every day to keep businesses and other organizations operating. Some situations follow:

- Letter requesting information about a product or service
- Letter inviting the reader to an event
- Memo summarizing the results of a meeting with a client
- Memo explaining a new laboratory procedure
- E-mail announcing a meeting

Use the following outline in writing your neutral correspondence. Also, refer to the M-Global examples that follow the outline.

ABC Format for Neutral Correspondence

Because the reader usually has no personal stake in the news, neutral correspondence requires less emphasis on tone and tact than other types, yet it still requires careful planning. In particular, always abide by this main rule:

Make your message absolutely clear.

Neutral correspondence operates a bit like good-news correspondence. You must make your point early, without giving the reader time to wonder about your message.

Neutral correspondence varies greatly in specific organization patterns. The *umbrella plan* suggested here emphasizes the main criterion of clarity.

M-Global Case Study for a Neutral Letter

Letters with neutral messages get written by the hundreds each week at M-Global. The letter in Model 6–6 on page 188 is typical. Farah Linkletter, a supply assistant with M-Global's San Francisco office, often writes letters to equipment suppliers. Instead of a salutation, her letter uses a subject line, much like a subject line used in memos or e-mail. It opens with a reference to an ongoing conversation and then clearly lists the requested items. It closes with a statement of the next steps in the process and a sentence that keeps the business relationship open.

M-Global Case Study for a Neutral Memo

When the Copy Center at M-Global changed its services, Gini Preston, Director of Copy Services, decided to write a memo to all employees. This memo is presented in Model 6–7 on page 189. She chose a memo instead of e-mail because the text is somewhat long for an e-mail, and because she wanted to use formatting that highlighted the major changes. The memo uses lists and bold type to help readers identify the important information. It includes the date on which the change will take place and closes with a phone number for those who have questions.

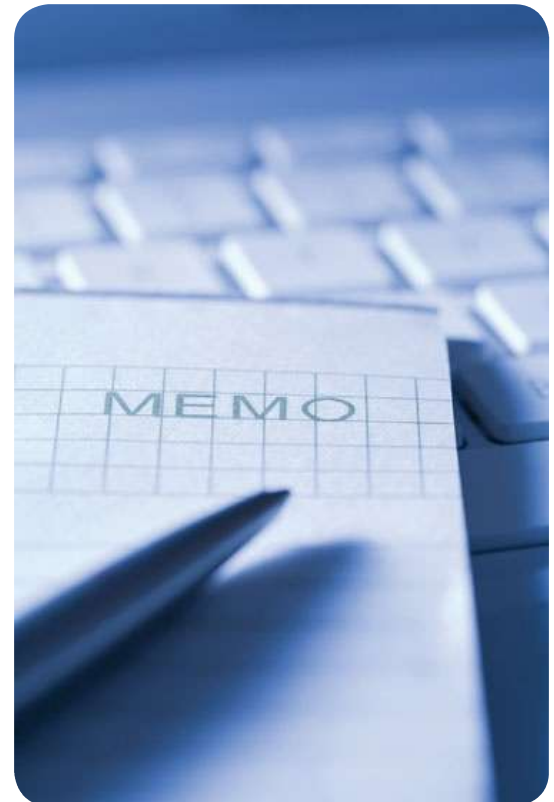
Persuasive Messages

When people think about persuasive writing in the workplace, they often think of proposals (like the ones discussed in Chapter 12). However, regular business correspondence often has a somewhat persuasive goal. Positive correspondence, like a letter of recommendation, or negative correspondence, like a letter explaining why a project is delayed, may have a persuasive tone. The following list will give you an idea of correspondence with a strong persuasive message:

- Letter starting a business relationship
- Letter registering complaints about products or services
- Letter seeking repeat business
- Memo requesting funding for a training seminar
- Memo explaining policy changes that may be perceived negatively
- E-mail encouraging employees to follow required procedures

ABC Format: Neutral Correspondence

- **ABSTRACT** Puts correspondence in the context of an ongoing professional relationship by referring to previous communication related to the subject
 - Precise purpose of correspondence (e.g., request, invitation, information about new procedure)
- **BODY:** Details that support the purpose statement (e.g., a description of items requested, the requirements related to the invitation, a description of changes in procedure)
- **CONCLUSION:** Statement of appreciation
 - Description of actions that should occur next



ABC Format for Persuasive Correspondence

The one main rule that governs all persuasive correspondence is as follows:

Help readers solve their problems.

You must engage the readers' interest by showing that you understand their needs and can help fulfill them. The ABC format offers a plan for writing successful persuasive correspondence. Note reference to the 3Cs (Capture/Convince/Contact) strategy mentioned earlier in the chapter.

M-Global Case Study for a Persuasive Letter

M-Global provides customers with professional services and equipment, so persuasive letters that sell the company services are important to the firm. Benjamin Feinstein is one employee who writes them almost every day. As a first-year employee with a degree in industrial hygiene, Benjamin works in the newly formed asbestos abatement group. The letter in Model 6–8 on page 190 is the first step in Benjamin's process of gaining new clients for M-Global. This letter will be followed by more letters, phone calls, and meetings, which Benjamin hopes will lead to negotiating a contract with the Jessup County School System. In his letter, Benjamin use the "you attitude" to emphasize how the school system's problem can be solved by M-Global.

ABC Format: Persuasive Correspondence

- **ABSTRACT:** Puts correspondence in the context of an ongoing professional relationship by referring to previous communication related to the subject. Identifies problem or issue to be addressed
 - Focuses on how the information in the correspondence will help the reader
- **BODY:** Puts strongest points first or last, to emphasize them for the reader.
 - Clear explanation of steps to be taken
 - Emphasis on benefit to the reader
 - Reference to any attachments
- **CONCLUSION:** Summary of actions requested, with emphasis on the benefit to the reader
 - Statement of what will happen next
 - Offer of further explanation or future contact

M-Global Case Study for a Persuasive Memo

As personnel director of M-Global's Cleveland office, Timothy Fu knows that employees are always concerned when their health benefits change. They are afraid that the process will be more complicated and that their health coverage will decrease. Timothy opens this memo by emphasizing the benefits of the change. Using questions as his headings allows him to respond directly to employees' concerns. To reduce anxiety and confusion among his readers, he lists only the three most important elements of the new program. Finally, he closes with contact information for employees who have questions.

>>> Letters

Letters are to your clients and vendors what memos are to your colleagues. They relay information quickly and keep business flowing. Letters use a professional tone, even if the sender and recipient are on a first-name basis or know each other personally. Letters are usually action-oriented and are used to conduct business and continue business relationships. The first paragraph of business letters should refer to this business relationship. If the letter is in response to a phone call, meeting, or other business

communication, that information should be included, with details of the date, method, and subject of the communication.

Although letters are generally used for corresponding with external audiences, they may be used for internal correspondence in special cases, true when correspondence relates to employment. When an employee is given official notice of a change in job status—whether a promotion or termination—this information is usually recorded in a letter, even if it is also delivered in person.

Another special type of letter is the *transmittal letter*. Transmittal letters, or cover letters, accompany longer formal documents such as reports or proposals. They tell the readers why they are receiving the document, and they highlight the most important information in the document. If they accompany a proposal, they usually have a strong persuasive tone. (See Chapter 10 for more about transmittal letters.)

>>> Memos

Even though e-mail has become common in the workplace, *memos* are still important. You write them to peers, subordinates, and superiors in your organization—from the first days of your career until you retire. Even if you work in an organization that uses e-mail extensively, you will still compose print messages that convey your point with brevity, clarity, and tact. Later, this chapter discusses the choice of whether to send a message as a memo or an e-mail.

Because many activities are competing for their time, readers expect information to be related as quickly and clearly as possible. Memos should be as self-contained as possible. If they are part of an ongoing series of correspondence, include enough information in the first sentences so that your reader immediately recognizes the context. Use headings and lists to help your reader find the information that he or she needs. While memos should be concise, they should be complete enough to be clear, and they should address your reader's concerns.

>>> E-mail

Electronic communication (*e-mail*) has become the preferred means of communication in most organizations. Some of us receive 100 or more messages a day. Because e-mail can be sent internally, within an organization, or externally, from one organization to another, specific e-mail guidelines are added to the general guidelines for correspondence earlier in the chapter.

Guidelines for E-mail

When writing e-mail, you should try to strike a balance between speed of delivery on one hand and quality of the communication to your reader on the other. In fact, the overriding rule for e-mail is as follows:

Don't send it too quickly!



By taking an extra minute to check the style and tone of your message, you have the best chance of sending an e-mail that will be well received.

>> E-mail Guideline 1: Use Style Appropriate to the Reader and Subject

E-mail sent early in a relationship with a client or other professional contact should be somewhat formal. It should be written more like a letter, with a salutation, closing, and complete sentences. E-mail written once a professional relationship has been established can use a more casual style. It can resemble conversation with the recipient on the phone. Sentence fragments and slang are acceptable, as long as they contribute to your objectives and are in good taste. Most important, avoid displaying a negative or angry tone. Don't push the Send button unless an e-mail will produce a constructive exchange.

>> E-mail Guideline 2: Be Sure Your Message Indicates the Context to Which It Applies

Tell your readers what the subject is and what prompted you to write your message. If you are replying to a message, be sure to include the previous message or summarize the message to which you are replying. Most e-mail software packages include a copy of the message to which you are replying, as in Model 6–3. However, you should make sure that you include only the messages that provide the context for your reader. Long strings of forwarded e-mail make it difficult to find the necessary information.

>> E-mail Guideline 3: Choose the Most Appropriate Method for Replying to a Message

Short e-mail messages may require that you write only a brief response at the beginning or end of the e-mail to which you are responding. For complex, multitopic messages, however, you may wish to split your reply by commenting on each point individually (Figure 6–5).

>> E-mail Guideline 4: Format Your Message Carefully

Because e-mail messages frequently replace more formal print-based documents, they should be organized and formatted so that the readers can easily locate the information you want to communicate.

- Use headings to identify important chunks of information.
- Use lists to display a series of information.
- Use sufficient white space to separate important chunks of information.
- Use separators to divide one piece of information from another.

Figure 6–6 illustrates an e-mail message with headings, separators, and white space.

>> E-mail Guideline 5: Chunk Information for Easy Scanning

Break the information into coherent chunks dealing with one specific topic, including all the details that a reader needs to get all of the essential information. Depending on

■ **Figure 6-5** ■ An e-mail message that separates different topics for reply

X-Sender: mckinley@mail2.m-global.com
Date: Tue, 11 Nov 2012 09:25:30 -0800
To: pcarmich@advantage.com
From: Mike McKinley <mckinley@mail2.m-global.com>
Subject: our recent visit
Mime-Version: 1.0

Dear Paul,

YOU WROTE:

>I hope that you had a good flight back home. I certainly enjoyed meeting you and look forward to the possibility of working with you this coming spring on the project that your firm, M-Global, may do for us.

REPLY:

The trip back was fine, but tiring. I enjoyed meeting you also and visiting with your staff. I particularly enjoyed meeting Harold Black, for he will be very valuable in developing the plans for the possible water purification plant.

YOU WROTE:

>If Advantage, Inc., does decide to build the water purification plant, we would be very interested in having M-Global's Mary Stevens as the project manager.

REPLY:

That certainly will be a possibility; Mary is one of our best managers.

YOU WROTE:

>After you left, I called the city administration here in Murrayville. M-Global does not need a business license for your work here, but, of course, you will need the necessary construction permits.

REPLY:

Thanks for taking care of this matter—I had not thought of that. We will supply the details to you for applying for the construction permits if you accept our proposal.

■ **Model 6-6** ■

E-mail message
with use of
appropriate
headings,
separators, and
white space

Date: Tue, 7 Oct. 2012 09:25:30 -0800
To: Branch employees
From: Paul Carmichael <pcarmich@advantage.com>
Subject: October update
Mime-Version: 1.0

This is the October Electronic Update for Advantage, Inc. If you do not wish to receive this electronic update, send a message to

pcarmich@advantage.com

With the message in the subject line: Unsubscribe.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Project managers' meeting

October 21—project managers meeting (notice the change of location):
Hereford building, room 209.

November department meetings

All departments will have their planning and reporting meetings on November 18 at noon, with a joint lunch in the main dining room and breakout sessions at 12:30. Meetings should conclude at 2 p.m.

'*****

December department meetings

NOTE CHANGE OF DATE: The December department meetings will be held on December 10 (second Wednesday), NOT December 17 (third Wednesday).

the nature of the information, include specific topic, time, date, location, and necessary prerequisites and details.

>> **E-mail Guideline 6: Use Copy Options Carefully**

E-mail makes it easy to send copies of the same message to a large number of people at once. Using this technique can be helpful, but it can also clog readers' inboxes with unwanted mail. Before you copy someone, make sure that person really needs to see

the message that you are sending. Also think carefully about how you list the recipients. The “To:” line indicates a primary audience of decision makers, participants, or operators. (See Chapter 2 for more on types of readers.) The “Cc:” line indicates a secondary audience that needs to be informed about the subject but is not expected to act. Finally, use the “Bc:” line very carefully. Copying someone without informing the person to whom the e-mail is addressed can be considered unethical. One good use of the “Bc:” line is to send a copy of your e-mail message to yourself, for your own records.

>> **E-mail Guideline 7: When Writing to Groups, Give Readers a Method to Abstain from Receiving Future Notices**

E-mail can easily become invasive and troublesome for recipients. You will gain favor—or at least not lose favor—if you are considerate and allow recipients to decide what e-mail they wish to receive. Figure 6–6 includes information about how to unsubscribe from the branch’s employee e-mail list.

>> **E-mail Guideline 8: When Writing to Groups, Suppress the E-mail Addresses of Recipients—Unless the Group Has Agreed to Let Addresses Be Known**

It is inappropriate to reveal the e-mail addresses of group members to other group members. Use the “Bc:” line to suppress group members’ addresses.

>> **E-mail Guideline 9: When Composing an Important Message, Consider Composing It With Your Word Processor**

Important e-mail messages should be not only clear in format but also correct in mechanics. Because e-mail software may not have a spelling checker, compose important messages with your word processor and use your spelling checker to check accuracy. Then either cut and paste it into an e-mail message or attach it as a file.

ABC Format for E-mail

Simply understanding that e-mail *should* have a format puts you ahead of many writers, who consider e-mail a license to ramble on without structure. Yes, e-mail is casual and quick, but that does not make it formless. The three-part ABC format resembles that used for letters.

Remember—your reader is confronted with many e-mails during the day. Furthermore, the configurations of some computers make reading a screen harder on the eyes than reading

E-mail Guidelines

- Use style appropriate to the reader and subject
- Be sure your message indicates the context to which it applies
- Choose the most appropriate method for replying to a message
- Format your message carefully
- Chunk information for easy scanning
- Use Copy options carefully
- When writing to groups, give readers a method to abstain from receiving future notices
- When writing to groups, suppress the e-mail addresses of recipients
- When composing an important message, consider composing it with your word processor

ABC Format: E-mail

- **ABSTRACT:** Casual, friendly greeting if justified by relationship
 - Short, clear statement of purpose for writing
 - List of main topics to be covered
- **BODY:** Supporting information for points mentioned in abstract
 - Use of short paragraphs that start with main ideas
 - Use of headings and lists
 - Use of abbreviations and jargon only when understood by all readers
- **CONCLUSION:** Summary of main point
 - Clarity about action that comes next

print memos. So give each e-mail a structure that makes it simple for your reader to find important information.

Appropriate Use and Style for E-mail

E-mail is an appropriate reflection of the speed at which we conduct business today. Indeed, it mirrors the pace of popular culture as well. Following are some of the obvious advantages that using e-mail provides:

- It gets to the intended receiver quickly.
- Its arrival can be confirmed easily.
- Your reader can reply to your message quickly.
- It's cheap to use—once you have invested in the hardware and software.
- It permits cheap transmission of multiple copies and attachments.

Adding to the ease of transmission is the fact that e-mail allows you to create mailing lists. One address label can be an umbrella for multiple recipients, saving you much time.

Of course, remember the flip side of this ease of use: E-mail is *not* private. Every time you send an e-mail, remember that it may be archived or forwarded, and may end up being read by “the world.” Either by mistake or design, many supposedly private e-mails are received by unintended readers.

E-mail communication is often considered less formal and therefore less demanding in its format and structure than print-based messages such as memos and letters. However, because e-mail messages have become so pervasive a means of communication, you should consider constructing them as carefully as you would other correspondence. Another reason to exercise great care is that e-mail, like conventional documents, can be used in legal proceedings and other formal contexts.

Chapter 3, which mentions e-mail in the context of team writing, shows how electronic mail helps you collaborate with others during the writing process—especially the planning stage. Interestingly, the e-mail medium has produced a casual writing style similar to that of handwritten notes. It even has its own set of abbreviations and shortcut languages, which ranges so widely and changes so often that no list of abbreviations is included here. Following is an e-mail message from one M-Global employee to another. Josh Bergen and Natalie Long are working together on a report in which they must offer suggestions for designing an operator's control panel at a large dam. Josh has just learned about another control panel that M-Global designed and installed for a Russian nuclear power plant (see Model 12–6 on pages 472–478). Josh wrote this e-mail message to draw Natalie's attention to the related M-Global project:

DATE: September 15, 2012

TO: Natalie Long

FROM: Josh Bergen

SUBJECT: Zanger Dam Project

Natalie—

I've got an idea that might save us A LOT of time on the Zanger Dam project. Check out the company project sheet on the Russian nuclear plant job done last year.

Operators of hi-tech dams and nuke plants seem to face the same hassles:

- confusing displays
- need to respond quickly
- distractions

When either a dam or nuke operator makes a mistake, there's often big trouble. I think we'd save time—and our client's money—if we could go right to some of the technical experts used in the nuke job. At least as a starting place. Maybe we'd even make our deadline on this project. That would be a change, considering the schedule delays this month on other jobs.

What do you think about this idea? Let me know today, if possible.

This message displays some of the most common stylistic features of electronic mail.

Model 6–10 on page 191 is another example of e-mail. Like the memo in Model 6–7, this e-mail explains a change in procedure. Note that even though the tone is less formal, as is appropriate to an in-house e-mail message like this one, the message meets the other guidelines for neutral correspondence that are discussed in on pages 164–165.

>>> Memos Versus E-mail

Although e-mail has become the most common form of internal correspondence in the workplace, there are times when a memo is a better option. Send a memo instead of an e-mail in the following situations.

- The document is longer than can be viewed easily on a computer screen.
- The document must include symbols, special characters, or other formatting that may not be available on all e-mail systems.
- The document includes graphics.
- The document must be posted in print form.
- The document contains sensitive information, including information about clients, projects, or personnel.

>>> Chapter Summary

- All correspondence should use the 3Cs strategy: Capture, Convince, and Contact.
- All correspondence should use the “You attitude.” The writer should identify the reader's interests and use those interests as a guide when writing letters, memos, or e-mail.

- The ABC format for correspondence provides a general framework for organizing messages.
- Specific ABC formats for positive, negative, neutral, and persuasive correspondence provide structure that tailors the message to its purpose.
- Letters are generally written to readers outside an organization. In personnel matters, letters may be written for correspondence within an organization. Letters are generally formal in tone.
- Memos are written from one member of an organization to another member of the same organization. Memos should be brief, but clear. Memos may use navigation tools such as headings to help readers find the information that they need.
- Because e-mail may be written to readers within or outside an organization, it deserves extra care.
- E-mail messages should be formatted so that the information in them is clear. Techniques include chunking information, separating information with headers, and using lists.
- The ABC format for e-mail provides a general structure for e-mail messages.
- E-mail style should be adapted to the audience and the business context. E-mail written to someone outside the organization may be written more like a letter. E-mail that is part of an ongoing conversation within an organization may be very informal.
- Memos should be sent instead of e-mail when documents are long, require special formatting or graphics, or will be posted in print form. Memos are also preferred for sensitive information.